

2-4b Totalitarianism

The opposite end of democracy is

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(also known as

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), which is defined as a political system in which one person or party exercises absolute political control over the population. There are four major types of totalitarianism.

- **Communist totalitarianism** centers on a communist party. This system had been embraced throughout Central and Eastern Europe and the former Soviet Union until the late 1980s. It is still practiced in China, Cuba, Laos, North Korea, and Vietnam.
- **Right-wing totalitarianism** is characterized by its intense hatred against communism. One party, typically backed by the military, restricts political freedom, arguing that such freedom would lead to communism. In postwar decades, Argentina, Brazil, Chile, the Philippines, South Africa, South Korea, and Taiwan practiced right-wing totalitarianism. Most of these countries have recently become democracies.
- **Theocratic totalitarianism** refers to the monopolization of political power in the hands of one religious party or group. Iran and Saudi Arabia are leading examples.
- **Tribal totalitarianism** refers to one tribe or ethnic group (which may or may not be the majority of the population) monopolizing political power and oppressing other tribes or ethnic groups. Rwanda's bloodbath in the 1990s was due to some of the most brutal practices of tribal totalitarianism.